# Introduction to Management MGNT110

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# Managing teams and groups

Lecture 3

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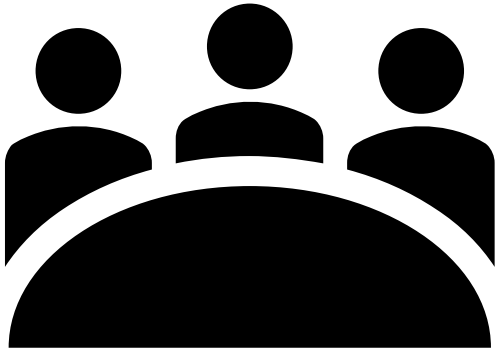
# Learning Objectives

- Group dynamics and the process of group development
- Team development
- A ‘dark-side’ to teams
- Toxic emotions



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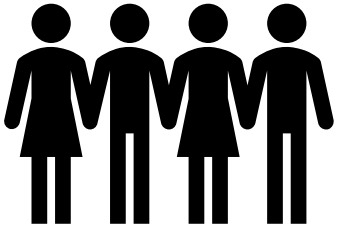
# A Team

- A *team* refers to:
  - Two or more people psychologically contracted together to achieve common goals, and share responsibility and accountability for outcomes
  - A psychological contract refers to the informal obligations between one person and another or within a group.

# A Group

- A *group* differs from a team:
  - Common goal but no psychological contract is involved
  - No interdependency is assumed



| Team | Group |
| --- | --- |
| • shared goal<br>• psychological contract<br>• interdependence<br>• shared accountability<br><br>Students working on assignment → depend on each other | • shared goal<br>BUT:<br>• no psychological contract<br>• no strong interdependence<br><br>Students sitting together but doing own work |

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# To build teams, we first need to understand groups

**Why Groups?**

- Safety/belonging
- e.g. New employee -> joins group to feel included

**Group types**

- Formal (work teams)
- Informal (friends)
- Open vs closed (exclusive)

**Group properties**

- Size (small vs large)
- Closeness (friends vs strangers)
- Strength of relationship

**Impact on performance**

- "Social facilitation"
  - psychologists found that:
    - People perform better when others are watching

**Conformance & obedience**

- People follow group even if wrong
  - Everyone agrees in meeting even if they disagree

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# Challenges in groups

**Groupthink**

**Groupthink is a mode of thinking that occurs when the desire for consensus within a group overrides individuals' motivation to critically evaluate alternative ideas or viewpoints, often leading to poor decision-making (Janis 1972).**

- **Everyone agrees too quickly**
- **No one challenges ideas**

**Social loafing**

**Social loafing refers to the tendency for individuals to exert less effort when working in a group compared to when working alone, due to reduced accountability and diffusion of responsibility (Latané, Williams and Harkins 1979).**

**People put in less effort in a group**
**"Someone else will do it" mindset**

# How to counter them?

**Groupthink**

**Why it is dangerous:**

- Poor decisions
- No critical thinking
- No innovation

**How to fix it:**

- Encourage opinions
- Allow disagreement
- Promote critique
- Reflect on decisions

**Social loafing**

**Why it is dangerous:**

- Unfair workload
- Low performance
- Team conflict

**How to fix it:**

- Clear roles
- Clear goals
- Accountability

# Differentiating teams

- Not all teams are the same, how do we classify them?
- 3 Key Dimensions

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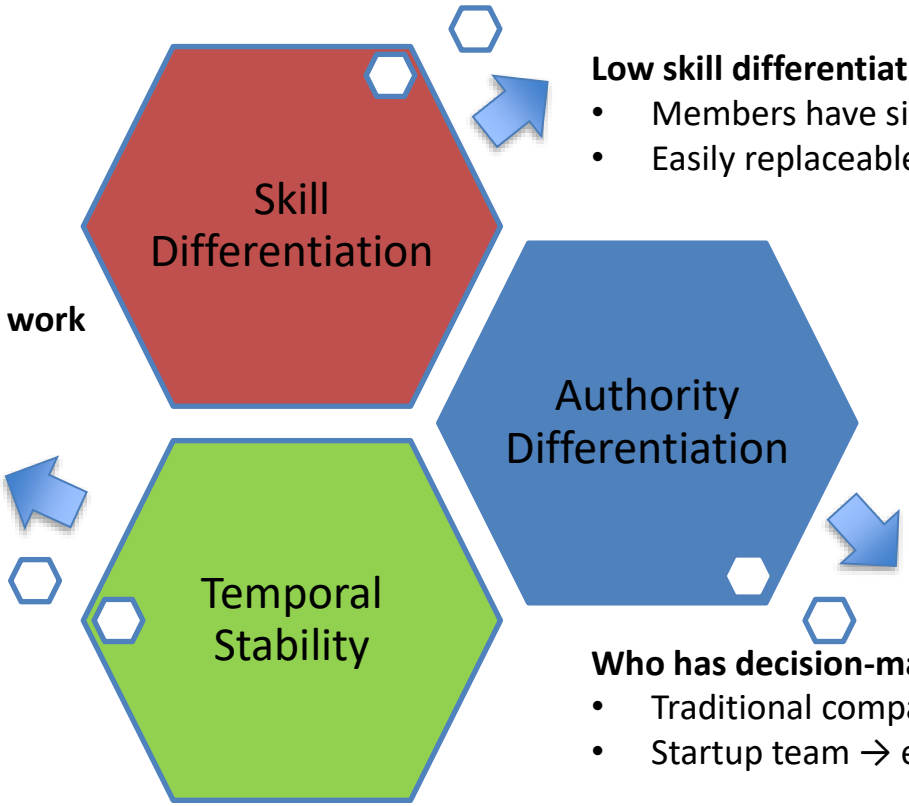
# 3 Key Dimensions

**High skill differentiation:**
- Each member has unique expertise
- Not easily replaceable

**Low skill differentiation:**
- Members have similar skills
- Easily replaceable




**How long team member work together.**

**High stability:**
- long-term team
- strong relationships
- high trust

**Low stability:**
- temporary team
- project-based
- less bonding

**Who has decision-making power**
- Traditional company → manager decides
- Startup team → everyone contributes

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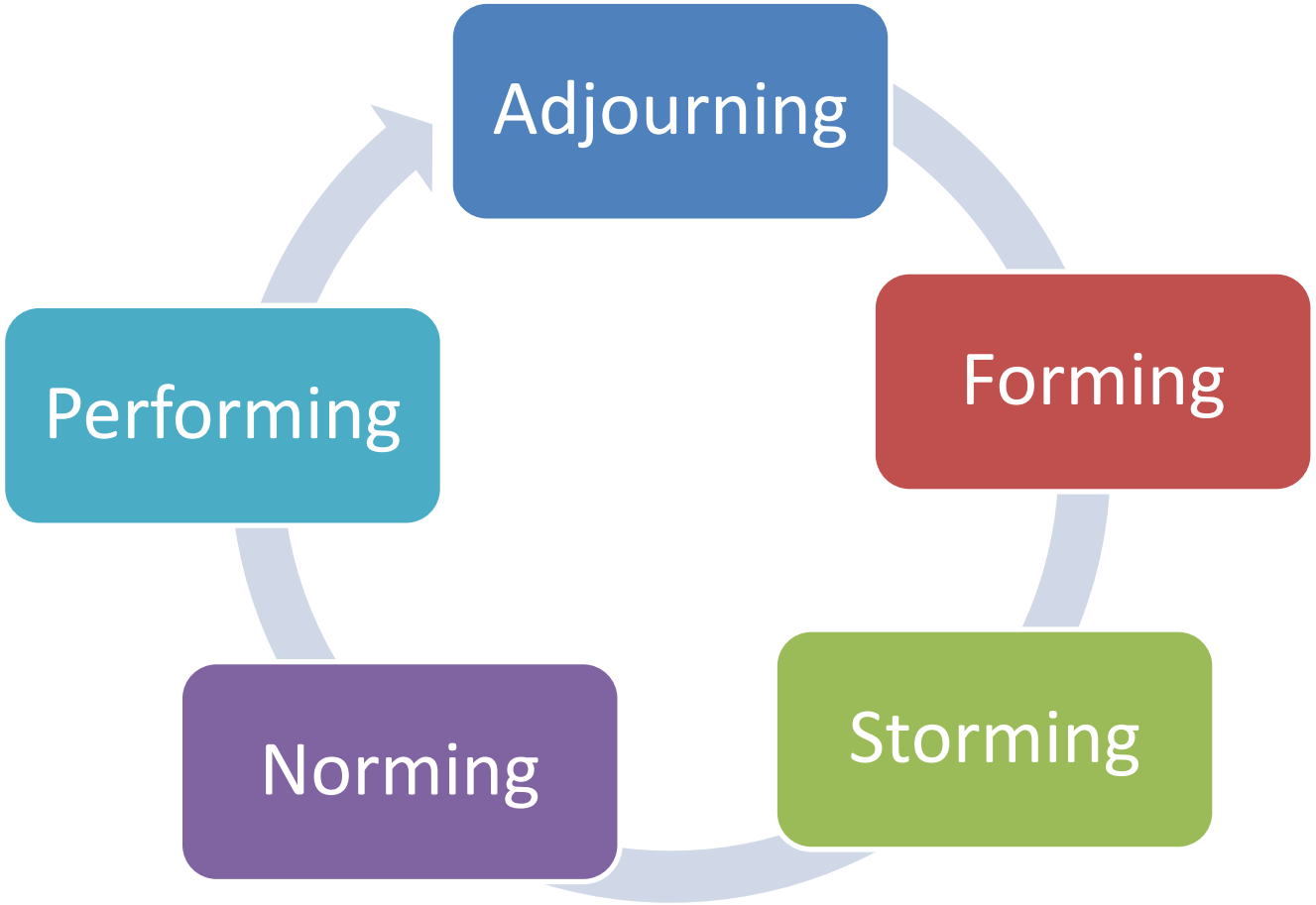
# Tuckman Model

(Tuckman & Jensen 1977).

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# Stages of group development

- Forming Orientation phase
- Storming Conflict phase
- Norming Emergence phase
- Performing Reinforcement phase
- Adjourning Disbanding phase

FoScNePrAd ?

FoStNoPA ?

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# Stages of group development

1. **Forming**
   - Getting to know you, ice-breaking stage
   - Attempt to identify what tasks they should be working on
   - Begin to develop a sense of the group's independence
   - Task (job-oriented) and socio-emotional (interpersonal) roles may be unclear

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# Stages of group development

2. **Storming**
   - Conflicts over leadership, control and influence — ‘who’s in charge?’
   - Misunderstandings about:
     - Role and style behaviour and norms
     - Conflicting goals
     - Poor feedback and listening
     - Ineffective group decision-making
     - Problem-solving processes

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# Stages of group development

3. **Norming**
   - Formal and informal norms emerge
   - Cohesion begins to develop
   - Opinions are now stated more readily and are received in a less defensive manner

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# Stages of group development

4. **Performing**
   - Balance of rules (norms) and roles emerge
   - Synergy develops via positive role-playing
   - Optimal mix of task (job-oriented) and socio-emotional (interpersonal) roles
   - Destructive role-playing under control
   - Begins to produce solutions to problems it is focusing on

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# Stages of group development

5. **Adjourning**
   - Reaches closure on tasks
   - Members may leave for a variety of reasons
   - Destructive role-playing may become more prevalent

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# Stages of group development

- All groups – all five stages?
- No, because they may:
  - Be ‘immortal’
  - Move between different stages
  - Self-destruct before reaching stages 3–5
  - Have no storming phase at all

# Managing team conflict

## The Seven Deadly INs

| | |
|---|---|
| **In**tention | When someone deliberately tries to hurt others |
| **In**competence | Lack of skills or ability |
| **In**fidelity | Betrayal of trust |
| **In**sensitivity | Lack of awareness of others' feelings |
| **In**trusion | Invading personal space or boundaries |
| **In**stitutional forces | Conflict caused by system or org |
| **In**evitability | Conflict is unavoidable |

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# How managers should respond?

- Instead of:
  - blaming individuals
- They should:
  - clarify roles
  - improve communication
  - manage expectations
  - support team members

# Summing up

- Teams are an important form
  - stimulate human relations that are productive, cohesive and aligned to organizational outcomes.
- Group dynamics affect performance
  - influenced by dynamics such as group size, cohesion and social facilitation, conformance and obedience.
- Teams develop through different stages
  - depending on what organizational tasks they are formed to work on.
- Managing teams is not just about structure; it's about managing behaviour, relationships, and conflict.

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